



Report Date: May 14, 2026

VanRIMS No.: 08-3000-30

[Submit comments to the Board](#)

TO: Park Board Chair and Commissioners
FROM: Director, Business Services
SUBJECT: Bard on the Beach - New Multi-Year Agreement Framework for Main Festival Site at Vanier Park

RECOMMENDATIONS

- A. THAT the Vancouver Board of Parks and Recreation ("Park Board") direct staff to explore the development of a new multi-year agreement framework for Bard on the Beach at their main festival location in Vanier Park;
- B. THAT, subject to a positive assessment, the Park Board direct staff to present the proposed terms of a new agreement framework to the Board at the earliest possible date; and
- C. THAT no legal rights or obligations shall arise, and no consents, permissions, or licenses are granted hereby, and none shall arise or be granted hereafter unless and until all contemplated legal documentation has been executed and delivered by all parties.

PURPOSE AND SUMMARY

Bard on the Beach ("BOTB" or "Festival") is Western Canada's largest not-for-profit professional Shakespeare Festival. The Festival is presented in Vancouver's Vanier Park against a backdrop of mountains, sea, and sky.

Like many other organizations in the performing arts sector, BOTB continues to face significant post-pandemic financial pressures. Staff from BOTB and the Park Board have worked collaboratively since 2024 to explore opportunities to address these financial challenges. A quick win opportunity (leaving the Festival's mainstage arches onsite at Vanier Park during the event's off-season) was identified and approved by the Board in October 2024. More recently, in March 2026, the Board approved the leasing of space to the Festival at the Burrard Civic Marina land storage lot for use as a temporary storage facility for a period of ten (10) years.

The purpose of this report is to present an additional and new opportunity which involves exploring the development of a long-term multi-year agreement framework for BOTB's main festival location in Vanier Park, explain the needs and benefits of this initiative, and seek the Board's approval to explore the opportunity for a period of up to ten (10) years.

BOARD AUTHORITY / PREVIOUS DECISIONS

Per the [Vancouver Charter](#), the Park Board has exclusive jurisdiction and control over parkland use in the City of Vancouver (including any structures, programs and activities, fees, and improvements within parks) and approves the use of all lands under its jurisdiction on such terms as the Park Board may decide.

On June 22, 2020, at an *in camera* meeting (with the decision subsequently made public in a [memo](#) to the Board on March 2, 2023), the Park Board approved a series of Planning Principles as a framework for initiating a collaborative master planning process for Vanier Park between the Park Board and the xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), Skwxwú7mesh Úxwumixw (Squamish), and səliłwətał (Tsleil-Waututh) peoples (“MST” or “Host Nations”). This work would be undertaken jointly with the City of Vancouver’s Arts, Culture and Community Services department (ACCS). While staff have undertaken initial outreach to the Host Nations, the timeline for undertaking a full planning process and associated public and stakeholder engagement is not currently confirmed.

On January 16, 2023, the Board approved the [“Think Big” Revenue Strategy motion](#) to prioritize and enable opportunities for increased commercial revenues. Subsequently, on July 17, 2023, the Board endorsed the Think Big Action Plan as presented in Appendix A in the [“Think Big” Revenue Strategy – Report Back: July 6, 2023](#), and further validated the preliminary revenue-generating opportunities presented in Appendix D, which included enabling seasonal/temporary park attractions/services and activating public spaces.

On October 21, 2024, at a public meeting, the Park Board [approved an application](#) from BOTB for a pilot program enabling the Festival’s mainstage arches to remain on site at Vanier Park during the event’s off-season between November 2024 and March 2025. The Board subsequently approved the continuation of this pilot program between November 2025 and March 2026, and conditionally in future years, at a public meeting on November 3, 2025.

On March 30, 2026, at a public meeting, the Park Board [approved an application](#) from BOTB to lease approximately 20,000 square feet of space in the Burrard Civic Marina land storage area for use as a temporary storage facility, including the installation of a 7,000 square foot Quonset tent structure, for a period of ten (10) years.

CONTEXT AND BACKGROUND

Overview

Established in 1990, Bard on the Beach is Western Canada’s largest not-for-profit professional Shakespeare Festival. A longstanding Vancouver favourite, the Festival is presented in Vancouver’s Vanier Park against a backdrop of mountains, sea, and sky, and offers Shakespeare plays, related dramas, and special events in two modern performance tents from June through September. The Festival is known for its signature blend of high-quality artistic programming and a welcoming, informal experience for local residents and visitors from around the world.

Financial Issues/Market Pressures

The performing arts sector continues to face significant post-pandemic pressures, and BOTB is navigating a particularly challenging financial reality. Since 2020, the Festival has experienced a sustained 20% decline in ticket sales alongside a 25% increase in operating costs, resulting in a projected deficit of more than \$1 million in 2026 without meaningful structural change. With only 4% of revenue coming from public funding – compared to 30 to 50% for peer organizations – BOTB relies heavily on earned income while absorbing the full cost of building, dismantling,

transporting, and storing its seasonal infrastructure each year. Despite generating significant amounts of parking revenue annually for the City and operating entirely on civic-managed land, the Festival remains ineligible for key municipal supports tied to civic facilities. In this context, reducing repeatable, structural costs has become an urgent strategic priority, allowing BOTB to protect its artistic, education, and community programs while improving environmental performance and ensuring long-term financial sustainability without increased reliance on public funding.

Collaborative Planning & Pilot Program

Staff from BOTB and the Park Board have been working collaboratively since 2024 to identify opportunities to address or reduce BOTB's financial pressures for the mutual benefit of the Festival, park users, and the Park Board. In particular, the financial and logistical realities of BOTB's signature infrastructure have become increasingly challenging and threaten the Festival's financial and programmatic sustainability. Through these discussions, a quick win pilot program opportunity was identified in late 2024 which involved leaving the Festival's mainstage arches onsite at Vanier Park during the event's off-season between mid-November and mid-March. The pilot program, which was successfully implemented and resulted in no park user/community complaints, was recently renewed for future years.

More recently, BOTB received approval to lease approximately 20,000 square feet of space in the Burrard Civic Marina land storage area for use as a temporary storage facility, including the installation of a 7,000 square foot Quonset tent structure, for a period of ten (10) years.

New Opportunity

Through on-going discussions between BOTB and Park Board staff, an additional opportunity has been identified with the potential to provide important expense and logistical relief for BOTB, while transferring no costs to the Park Board, enabling additional Park Board revenue streams, and improving park usability during off-season months. This new opportunity involves supporting BOTB by exploring the development of a new long term multi-year agreement framework of up to 10-years (as opposed to the annual permit process which has been in place since 1990).

DISCUSSION

Program Proposal

Building on the success of the above-mentioned initiatives, BOTB is seeking the Park Board's support to work with Park Board staff to investigate and explore a broader, more coordinated strategy that would enable additional investments to enhance overall park usability and allow additional physical assets to remain in the park year-round. These assets would not be permanent, would continue to meet high standards of security, accessibility, and financial prudence, and would remain removable if required. The intent of this next phase is to:

- Reduce repeated annual construction and dismantling activities;
- Minimize environmental impacts;
- Lower long-term operating costs for BOTB; and
- Improve park usability, accessibility and public enjoyment.

To enable the cost reductions and operational efficiencies associated with expanded year-round infrastructure, BOTB is requesting that this investigation be considered alongside a longer-term planning framework, including up to a ten (10) year agreement for its Vanier Park operations. Lease certainty is essential to responsibly investing in non-permanent, reversible infrastructure,

amortize capital improvements, reduce risk from repeated short-term approvals, and align multi-year planning with Park Board asset management and VanPlay objectives.

Areas or opportunities for investigation and collaboration include:

- **Winterizing and retaining the Mainstage tent year-round**

The Mainstage tent and its seating platforms are currently dismantled for just over four months each year, then rebuilt in the spring. Leaving the structure in place through the offseason could result in significant annual operating savings while reducing labour demands, emissions, and wear on the park.

- **Adding anchor points for the smaller theatre tent**

Similar to improvements made to the Mainstage tent in 2011, BOTB would like to investigate adding anchor points to streamline set-up, improve safety, and reduce installation time and cost for the Douglas Campbell Theatre tent.

- **Upgrading gravel pathways for year-round use**

The gravel paths introduced during the pilot successfully improved traffic flow, reduced machinery damage, and increased accessibility. BOTB would like to expand this initiative and proposes exploring weather-resistant, year-round pathway solutions that would:

- Eliminate annual installation costs
- Reduce lumber use and waste
- Improve accessibility during BOTB's season and in the off-season
- Enhance the park experience for all users

- **Exploring a year-round marquee or covered gathering structure**

Bard would like to investigate options for a multi-use tent or shelter that could serve as a special-events venue during the season and remain in place during the winter as a covered public gathering space. Early concepts under consideration include gazebo-style or other aesthetically integrated structures that provide public benefit beyond BOTB's programming.

- **Reimagining Bard's main entranceway**

First discussed with the Parks Board in 2014, BOTB proposes revisiting ideas for a redesigned entrance that could incorporate park amenities such as benches or shelter, while serving as a welcoming and celebratory marker of Vanier Park as Bard on the Beach's summer home. An additional idea is to work with the Squamish Nation to use this piece as a monument, art installation and/or education opportunity dedicated to the indigenous history of the area.

- **Investigating washroom trailer solutions**

BOTB seeks to explore the feasibility and cost-effectiveness of purchasing washroom trailers with flush toilets and running water. This would:

- Improve comfort for staff, artists, patrons, and volunteers
- Better align with BC legislation regarding worker facilities
- Reduce reliance on portable toilets and waste-removal trucks

Program Benefits

This proposed exploration aligns with the Parks Board's goals around sustainability, accessibility, safety, and efficient use of park assets. It builds on past proven initiatives, poses minimal risk, and offers the potential for:

- Reduce repeated annual construction and dismantling activities;
- Reduced environmental impacts;
- Enable long-term cost efficiencies for BOTB;
- Support a stronger, more resilient cultural partner within Vanier Park;
- Improve park amenities, accessibility and overall experience;
- Enhance year-round park activation and programming; and
- Generate incremental revenues which can be used to provide broader parks and recreation public service delivery.

FINANCIAL CONSIDERATIONS

Subject to Board approval, Park Board staff will work with Festival organizers to explore the feasibility of a New Agreement Framework for BOTB's Main Festival Site at Vanier Park. While this initiative will require an investment in staff time, there will be no incremental costs to the Park Board related to this initiative.

OTHER CONSIDERATIONS

Subject to Park Board approval, Park Board staff will work collaboratively with BOTB staff to explore the development of a new multi-year agreement framework. Engagement will also take place with appropriate internal and external stakeholders and xʷməθkʷəy̓əm (Musqueam), Sk̓wx̓wú7mesh Úxwumixw (Squamish), and səliłwətał (Tsleil-Waututh) rightsholders.

A separate referral was previously issued to all three Nations to initiate a collaborative park planning process for Vanier Park. All three Nations have expressed interest in the planning process and Park Board staff are equally interested in advancing this effort. The Vanier Park plan is distinct and separate from this new 10-year agreement framework which does not preclude or alter that invitation to all three Nations on broader planning of Vanier Park.

Navigating the impacts of a potential 10-year agreement with the Nations and the broader Vanier Park planning effort will be a key consideration during the exploration and assessment effort. Staff will look to ensure appropriate mitigation efforts are developed and implemented to minimize any identified impacts. Any unmitigated risks will be clearly articulated when brought to the Board for consideration.

No legal agreements, rights or obligations shall arise from this initiative. If the exploration of a new agreement framework proves successful, it will be brought to the Board for review and consideration.

CONCLUSION AND NEXT STEPS

Bard on the Beach is Western Canada's largest not-for-profit, professional Shakespeare Festival. Faced with emerging financial and operational pressures, staff from both organizations are engaging collaboratively to identify opportunities to enable Festival cost savings and enhance Park Board revenue streams.

After past successful initiatives, a new opportunity has been identified to support the Festival by exploring the development of a new agreement framework. Park Board staff have carefully reviewed the various considerations of this opportunity and recommend that the Board approve the recommendations as outlined in this report.

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